Conference was held in Bezwada [Vijayawada]. The holy and learned Swami who opened the Conference told us that ‘co-education, divorce and post-puberty marriages would mean the annihilation of Hinduism’. I had not realized till then that these three or rather the absence of them, were the main props of Hinduism – this is rather involved but I suppose my meaning is clear. The chairman of the Reception Committee of that Conference further told us that he ‘viewed with grave concern the growth of the Indian women’s movement and asserted that the women who were fighting for equal rights with men did not represent the real women of India. They are merely agitators who have thrown modesty – the outstanding quality of Indian women – to the winds.’

I am afraid I cannot bring myself to agree with Sir Mohamad Iqbal and the *sanatanists*. Partly, the reason perhaps is a personal and selfish one. I do not think I shall get on at all under their joint regime, I may even land myself in prison. I have spent a long enough period of my life in prison under the British Government and I see no particular reason why I should add to it under the new dispensation. But my personal fate is of little account, what matters is the larger theme of India and her millions. It is an astonishing thing to me that while our millions starve and live like beasts of the field, we ignore their lot and talk of vague metaphysical ideas and the good of their souls; that we shirk the problems of today in futile debate about yesterday and the day before yesterday; that when thoughtful men and women all over the world are considering problems of human welfare and how to lessen human misery and stupidity, we, who need betterment and raising most, should think complacently of what our ancestors did thousands of years ago and for ourselves should continue to grovel on the ground. It astonishes me that a poet like Sir Mohamad Iqbal should be insensitive to the suffering that surrounds him, that a scholar and thinker like Sir Mohamad should put forward fantastic schemes of states within states, and advocate a social structure which may have suited a past age but is a hopeless anachronism today. Does his reading of history not tell him that nations fell because they could not adapt themselves to changing conditions and because they stuck too long to that very structure which he